

3/1/2025 via FDMS

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I'm an Assistant Professor at a small private school, Concordia University Wisconsin. I received a National Artificial Intelligence Research Resource (NAIRR) grant in October 2024 for my work in privacy preserving machine learning with education data. We were one of the non-R1 universities to receive a grant and this helped small institutions to do research that has typically only been available to R1 universities. We also partnered with the company OpenMined who is a small startup that was able to participate in an area typically dominated by the big tech companies. I hope that the US government will consider fully funding the NAIRR beyond the pilot stage to put us on a path to more democratized access to AI which allows more researchers to help advance the US capabilities in this area.